Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Theodore Roethke's "Orchids"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of this poem include

alliteration,
assonance,
contrast,
diction,
imagery,
metaphor,
optimism,
personification,
sigmatism,
simile sympathy/empathy,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to consider the persona's sensitivity to nature and his appreciation for the organic processes that define the natural world, an appreciation that drives his near-spiritual description of the orchids that is the poem "Orchids."

The imagery is visual and tactile (as well as olfactory); additionally, the word choices suggest a personification (not unlike we find in Wordsworth's daffodil poem). The Roethke-familiar contestant might compare the proximity described in line three and elsewhere to the proximity that shocks in "The Bat."

The young writer might dwell on Roethke's tactile imagery as representative to the poet's sensitivity to nature.

The contestant might see Roethke's focus on the natural world as represented in these orchids as a sensing that there is much more at work than simple botanical growth. The growth of the orchids might be recognized as the growth of an individual's soul, primal in its "Moving slowly / Drawing in the warm air. / [. . .] / The heat going down / [. . .] / Drifting down / [. . .] / Breathing."